

Companion System — Inkglass Odyssey

Design document. Read before working on relay/companions/, companion-related endpoints, or NPC companion_data fields.

Cross-references: docs/combat_system.md (HP, conditions, exhaustion), docs/narrative_control.md (companion dismissal/reunion via panels), docs/schemas_reference.md (npc_personality.json companion_data).

Recruitment

Companions are recruited through authored recruitment scenarios gated behind: affection_threshold (minimum relationship score), recruitment_scenario_id (the narrative milestone), and recruitment_conditions (additional world-state flags). Recruitment is always in-game — never from a menu. See docs/narrative-control-ui.pdf for the full recruitment schema.

Companion Limit

Maximum active companions: defined in world_config.json as max_active_companions. Default: 1. Recommended maximum: 2. The atla_au sky companion counts toward this cap.

Combat Profile

Companions have simplified stat blocks: level, HP (same formula as player characters), one primary ability score, AC, and 2–3 abilities from the world’s ability library. They do not have full character sheets.

In combat, the relay resolves one automatic action per companion per turn based on behavior_type:

Behavior type	Default action
aggressive	Attacks the player’s current target
supportive	Heals or buffs the player (or lowest-HP ally in multiplayer)
defensive	Interposes and draws aggression, prioritising protect actions

The player can issue general directives in prose: "stay back," "protect the merchant," "focus the caster." The implicit check system parses these as companion directives and the relay maps them to behavior changes: "stay back" → defensive, "focus the caster" → aggressive with target override. Recognised directives are defined per companion in `directive_vocabulary`.

Companion Incapacitation

At 0 HP, companions withdraw from combat — narratively retreating or collapsing. They become unavailable for the remainder of the encounter. Companions never enter the player death spiral and are never permanently killed.

After combat ends, they recover automatically, but: gain 1 exhaustion level (cleared on next rest), relationship score decreases by the companion's `dismissal_relationship_modifier` value, and a `loyalty_strain` counter increments by 1.

When `loyalty_strain` reaches a threshold (default: 3, configurable per companion), the companion initiates a confrontation scene — a mandatory RP interaction where the companion expresses frustration, fear, or desire to leave. The player can address the strain through dialogue, but repeated incapacitation will eventually cause the companion to leave via their `farewell_template`. This creates a consequence for carelessness without silently deleting authored content.

Ambient Behaviour

Companions comment unprompted based on `ambient_behavior` configuration: `comment_frequency` (probability per turn or every N turns), `trigger_categories` (`new_region`, `npc_interaction_start`, `combat_start`, `player_idle`, `weather_change`, `world_event`), and `mood_modifier` (adjusts tone based on current relationship score and `loyalty_strain`). Comments use the companion's personality file voice and are injected into the scene flow by the narrator.

World event reactions (`world_event_reactions` array) provide event-specific comments with relationship modifiers — companions have opinions about world events.

Persistence Across Sessions

Companion state (HP, conditions, relationship score, `loyalty_strain`, exhaustion) is included in the session summary snapshot (POST `/session/end`). On session start, the relay loads last-known state from the database, not from personality file defaults. Companions who were exhausted and frustrated at session end remain so at next session start.

Reunion After World Reset

After a world reset, if the player had previously completed a companion's recruitment scenario (recorded in the archived snapshot), the relay offers a fast-track reunion: a shortened encounter using the companion's `reunion_template` that acknowledges the existing bond without replaying the full recruitment questline.

Companion Dismissal

Solo players can dismiss a companion from the Narrative Control Panel. This triggers the companion's `farewell_template` — a narrative event, not a silent state deletion. The relay fires the farewell sequence before clearing the companion flag. Dismissal applies the `dismissal_relationship_modifier` to the relationship score.